

Manatee

Manatees are gentle, roly-poly mammals with wide flippers and giant noses. They cruise slowly along rivers, swamps, and seashores, nibbling seagrass in underwater meadows for up to eight hours a day. As manatees digest their meals they produce lots of gas, which makes them blow up like balloons. Luckily, they have massive, heavy bones to weigh them down, or they wouldn't be able to sink below the surface.

In 1493, the explorer Christopher Columbus saw some strange animals swimming off the coast of North America. They were manatees, but he thought they were mermaids! Many other sailors have also mistaken manatees for these mythical creatures.

